

## HIDDEN GEMS

*A YouTube Discovery Platform Initiative*

# User Stories

Hidden Gems — Niche Creator Discovery Platform

*Agile User Story Backlog*

|                         |                                               |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| <b>Project</b>          | Hidden Gems Discovery Layer (YouTube)         |
| <b>Document Version</b> | 1.0                                           |
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## Document Control

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### Revision History

| Version | Date       | Author        | Description of Change                        |
|---------|------------|---------------|----------------------------------------------|
| 0.1     | 2026-07-01 | Product Owner | Initial epic breakdown                       |
| 0.5     | 2026-07-08 | Scrum Team    | Backlog grooming — acceptance criteria added |
| 1.0     | 2026-07-14 | Product Owner | Baselined for Phase 1 sprint planning        |

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## 1. Backlog Overview

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This backlog decomposes the Hidden Gems functional scope (see FTRD v1.0) into INVEST-compliant user stories, organized under six epics aligned to the functional modules. Each story includes a unique ID, narrative, acceptance criteria in Given/When/Then form, story point estimate (Fibonacci scale), MoSCoW priority, and the traced functional requirement(s).

| Epic ID | Epic Name                          | Goal                                                                                  |
|---------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| EPIC-1  | Creator Labeling Experience        | Let creators describe their content so it can be discovered by the right viewers.     |
| EPIC-2  | AI Label Verification & Moderation | Ensure only accurate, safe labels reach the discovery surface.                        |
| EPIC-3  | Viewer Discovery Surface           | Give viewers a dedicated place to find fresh, niche content.                          |
| EPIC-4  | Search by Intent                   | Let viewers search directly for the niche content they want.                          |
| EPIC-5  | Watch Page & Profile Integration   | Extend discovery beyond the home surface to the moments a viewer is already watching. |
| EPIC-6  | Attribution, Analytics & Trust     | Prove the surface is working and keep the ecosystem safe from abuse.                  |

## 2. Epic 1 — Creator Labeling Experience

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-101   | EPIC-1 | 5            | Must     | FR-M1-02  |

### Suggest labels during upload

*As a mid-tier creator, I want the system to suggest relevant niche labels while I'm uploading my video, so that I can quickly tag my content without researching taxonomy myself.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given I have uploaded a video and entered a title/description, when the upload screen loads, then the system displays at least 3 suggested labels relevant to my content.
- Given suggested labels are shown, when I tap a suggested label, then it is added to my video's label list.
- Given no confident suggestions exist, when the upload screen loads, then the system shows an empty state prompting me to add a custom label.

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-102   | EPIC-1 | 3            | Must     | FR-M1-03  |

### Add a custom label

*As a creator, I want to type in my own custom niche label, so that I can describe my content precisely even if it isn't in the suggested list.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given I am on the labeling step, when I type a custom label and submit, then it is sent to AI verification before becoming public.
- Given my custom label matches an existing taxonomy entry, when I submit it, then the system merges it with the existing approved label rather than creating a duplicate.

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-103   | EPIC-1 | 2            | Should   | FR-M1-04  |

### See reach-uplift messaging

*As a creator, I want to see how much labeling can improve my reach, so that I'm motivated to complete the labeling step instead of skipping it.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given I am on the labeling step with zero labels added, when the screen renders, then I see a message estimating reach improvement (e.g., "~3× more reach") sourced from current program data.

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-104   | EPIC-1 | 3            | Must     | FR-M1-05  |

### Edit labels after publish

*As a creator, I want to edit or remove labels on a video I already published, so that I can correct or refine how my content is categorized over time.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given I open a published video in Creator Studio, when I navigate to labels, then I can add, edit, or remove labels.

- Given I remove a label, when I save, then the video is no longer eligible for discovery under that label within one indexing cycle.

### 3. Epic 2 — AI Label Verification & Moderation

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-201   | EPIC-2 | 8            | Must     | FR-M2-01  |

#### Automated label verification

*As a platform (system), I want to automatically verify every submitted label against taxonomy and content signals, so that only accurate labels reach viewers and abuse is minimized.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given a creator submits a label, when verification runs, then the system returns approved, rejected, or needs-review within the defined SLA.
- Given the verification model's confidence score is below the review threshold, when a decision is made, then the label is routed to the human moderation queue.

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-202   | EPIC-2 | 3            | Must     | FR-M2-02  |

#### Notify creator of rejected label

*As a creator, I want to be told why my label was rejected, so that I can correct it and resubmit.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given my label is rejected, when I view my video in Creator Studio, then I see a rejection reason and a way to edit and resubmit the label.

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to          |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|--------------------|
| US-203   | EPIC-2 | 5            | Must     | FR-M8-01, FR-M8-02 |

#### Moderator review queue

*As a Trust & Safety moderator, I want a queue of flagged labels awaiting human review, so that I can approve, reject, or edit borderline labels before they go live.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given a label is flagged as needs-review, when I open the moderation queue, then I see the label, the associated video, and the AI's confidence score.
- Given I approve or reject a label, when I submit my decision, then it is logged with my identity, timestamp, and rationale.

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-204   | EPIC-2 | 5            | Should   | FR-M8-03  |

#### Suspend repeat-offender labeling privileges

*As a Trust & Safety moderator, I want to suspend a creator's ability to submit new labels after repeated violations, so that the labeling ecosystem stays trustworthy for viewers.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given a creator has 3 or more rejected labels within a rolling 30-day window, when I review their history, then I can suspend their labeling privileges with a stated duration.

## 4. Epic 3 — Viewer Discovery Surface

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to          |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|--------------------|
| US-301   | EPIC-3 | 5            | Must     | FR-M3-01, FR-M3-03 |

### View Hidden Gems on home tab

*As a high-intent viewer, I want to see a dedicated Hidden Gems section on my YouTube home tab, so that I can discover fresh, niche content I wouldn't otherwise find.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given I am an eligible viewer, when I open the YouTube home tab, then I see a Hidden Gems section with video cards labeled "Hidden Gem."
- Given a Hidden Gem card is displayed, when I view it, then it shows the video thumbnail, title, creator name, subscriber tier, and view count.

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-302   | EPIC-3 | 5            | Must     | FR-M3-02  |

### Filter by niche preference chip

*As a viewer, I want to tap a niche chip (e.g., Cinematography, Chess, Slow Living), so that I can quickly narrow the surface to what I care about right now.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given I am viewing the Hidden Gems surface, when I tap a niche chip, then the card list updates to show only content matching that niche within 400ms (p95).
- Given I have selected a chip previously, when I return to the surface, then my last-selected chip is remembered for this session.

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-303   | EPIC-3 | 3            | Should   | FR-M3-04  |

### Fresh content rotation

*As a returning viewer, I want the Hidden Gems surface to refresh with new content regularly, so that I don't see the same videos every time I open the app.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given I visited the Hidden Gems surface yesterday, when I return today, then at least 30% of surfaced cards are new relative to my last session.

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-304   | EPIC-3 | 3            | Could    | FR-M3-05  |

### Dismiss an irrelevant Hidden Gem

*As a viewer, I want to dismiss a Hidden Gem card that isn't relevant to me, so that future recommendations improve and I stop seeing similar content.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given a Hidden Gem card is displayed, when I long-press and select "Not interested," then the card is removed and the signal is fed back into ranking.

## 5. Epic 4 — Search by Intent

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| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-401   | EPIC-4 | 5            | Must     | FR-M4-01  |

### Search by niche label

*As a viewer, I want to search using a niche or intent term (e.g., “cinematography”), so that I'm routed to niche creators matching that exact interest.*

### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given I search a term that matches an approved taxonomy label, when results render, then Hidden Gems content for that label appears in a distinct, badged section above or alongside standard results.

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-402   | EPIC-4 | 3            | Should   | FR-M4-02  |

### Label autocomplete in search

*As a viewer, I want autocomplete suggestions of known niche labels as I type, so that I can find the right search term faster.*

### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given I type at least 2 characters in search, when matching taxonomy labels exist, then up to 5 suggestions appear below the search bar.

## 6. Epic 5 — Watch Page & Profile Integration

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-501   | EPIC-5 | 2            | Should   | FR-M6-01  |

### See 'Featured in Hidden Gems' badge

*As a viewer, I want to see a badge on the watch page when a video is part of Hidden Gems, so that I understand why this video is being recommended to me.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given I open a video that is Hidden Gems eligible, when the watch page renders, then a “Featured in Hidden Gems” badge is visible near the title.

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-502   | EPIC-5 | 3            | Should   | FR-M6-02  |

### See related Gems on watch page

*As a viewer, I want to see more Hidden Gems with the same label or from the same creator while watching, so that I can keep exploring the niche I'm already interested in.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given I am watching a Hidden Gem, when I scroll to related content, then I see a module titled “More with label: <label>” and a module titled “More gems from <creator>.”

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-503   | EPIC-5 | 2            | Must     | FR-M6-03  |

### Navigate to creator profile from a Gem

*As a viewer, I want to tap through from a Hidden Gem to the creator's profile, so that I can explore more of their content and subscribe.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given I am viewing a Hidden Gem card or watch page, when I tap the creator's name, then I am taken directly to their profile page.

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-504   | EPIC-5 | 3            | Should   | FR-M6-04  |

### See active labels on creator profile

*As a viewer, I want to see a creator's active niche labels on their profile, so that I know what kind of content to expect from them.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given I visit a creator's profile who has Hidden Gems content, when the profile renders, then their active labels are shown as chips near the subscribe button.

## 7. Epic 6 — Attribution, Analytics & Trust

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-601   | EPIC-6 | 8            | Must     | FR-M7-01  |

### Attribute visits to Hidden Gems

*As a platform (system), I want to attribute a profile visit or subscribe to Hidden Gems when it originated from the surface, so that creator impact can be measured accurately for the North Star Metric.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given a viewer clicks a Hidden Gems card and later visits the creator's profile within the attribution window, when the event is logged, then it is tagged with source = hidden\_gems.

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-602   | EPIC-6 | 8            | Must     | FR-M7-02  |

### Attribute revenue to Hidden Gems

*As a platform (system), I want to attribute ad, membership, and Super Chat revenue to Hidden Gems using consistent rules, so that creator and business revenue impact can be reported reliably.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given a revenue event occurs within the attribution window of a Hidden Gems impression, when the event is processed, then it is tagged with source = hidden\_gems and included in revenue reporting.

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-603   | EPIC-6 | 5            | Should   | FR-M7-03  |

### Creator analytics dashboard

*As a creator, I want to view a dashboard of my Hidden Gems views, CTR, and attributed revenue, so that I can understand the ROI of labeling my content.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given I open Creator Studio analytics, when I select the Hidden Gems tab, then I see views, CTR, subscribes, and revenue attributed to Hidden Gems for the selected date range.

| Story ID | Epic   | Story Points | Priority | Traces to |
|----------|--------|--------------|----------|-----------|
| US-604   | EPIC-6 | 5            | Must     | FR-M7-04  |

### Internal North Star reporting

*As a product manager, I want a daily internal report of the North Star Metric and supporting L1/L2 metrics, so that I can track program health and make data-driven rollout decisions.*

#### Acceptance Criteria:

- Given the reporting job runs daily, when it completes, then a dashboard is updated with incremental daily visits, engagement, and revenue metrics broken out by phase cohort.

## 8. Backlog Summary

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| Epic                             | # Stories | Total Points | Must-Have Points |
|----------------------------------|-----------|--------------|------------------|
| EPIC-1 Creator Labeling          | 4         | 13           | 10               |
| EPIC-2 Verification & Moderation | 4         | 21           | 16               |
| EPIC-3 Viewer Discovery Surface  | 4         | 16           | 10               |
| EPIC-4 Search by Intent          | 2         | 8            | 5                |
| EPIC-5 Watch Page & Profile      | 4         | 10           | 2                |
| EPIC-6 Attribution & Trust       | 4         | 26           | 21               |
| <b>Total</b>                     | <b>22</b> | <b>94</b>    | <b>64</b>        |

Recommended Phase 1 (closed creator beta) scope: EPIC-1 and EPIC-2 in full, plus US-604 for internal reporting readiness. Recommended Phase 2 (viewer rollout) scope: EPIC-3, EPIC-4, EPIC-5, and remaining EPIC-6 stories.